Corrective and Preventive Action Procedure

Purpose

This procedure defines the system for implementing and verifying corrective and preventive actions to eliminate the causes of non-conformances and prevent recurrence.

Scope

This procedure applies to all corrective and preventive actions at Acme Corporation, including those triggered by NCRs, audit findings, customer complaints, and improvement initiatives.

Definitions

CAPA: Corrective and Preventive Action — a systematic process to eliminate causes of non-conformances.

Corrective Action: Action to eliminate the cause of a detected non-conformance and prevent recurrence.

Preventive Action: Action to eliminate the cause of a potential non-conformance.

Effectiveness Check: Verification that the implemented action achieves the intended result.

Procedure

Step 1: Initiation

A CAPA is initiated when any of the following occur:

- An NCR is classified as Critical or Major (per SOP-QA-012)
- An audit finding identifies a systemic issue
- A customer complaint indicates a process failure
- Recurring non-conformances (three or more similar NCRs in 90 days)
- Management review identifies improvement opportunities

The QA Engineer opens a CAPA record with a unique number (format: CAPA-YYYY-XXXX).

Step 2: Problem Description

Define the problem clearly and quantitatively:

- What happened? Include objective evidence.
- When did it happen? Dates and shift information.
- Where did it happen? Production line, station, process step.

- How big is the impact? Quantity affected, cost impact, customer impact.
- How was it detected? Inspection, test, customer feedback.

Step 3: Containment

Implement immediate containment actions to protect the customer:

- Quarantine affected products
- Sort and inspect inventory
- Protect work in process
- Notify customers if applicable

Document containment effectiveness within 48 hours.

Step 4: Root Cause Analysis

Perform root cause analysis using approved methods:

5 Whys: Drill down from symptom to root cause by asking "why" iteratively.

Fishbone Diagram: Analyze six categories: Man, Machine, Material, Method, Measurement, Environment.

Data Analysis: Use statistical tools (control charts, Pareto analysis, hypothesis testing) when sufficient data exists.

Document the verified root cause with supporting evidence.

Step 5: Action Plan

Define corrective actions that address the root cause:

Action	Owner	Due Date	Expected Result
Update WI-034	QA Engineer	14 days	Clear pressure limits
Retrain operators	Production Manager	7 days	100% operator competency
Install pressure alarm	Maintenance	30 days	Real-time alert

Each action must have a single owner, a specific due date, and a measurable expected result.

Step 6: Implementation

Execute the action plan. The QA Engineer tracks progress weekly. Escalate overdue actions to the QA Manager.

Step 7: Effectiveness Check

Within 30 days of implementation completion, verify effectiveness:

- Collect data for at least 30 production cycles (or as specified in the plan)
- Compare before-and-after data
- Confirm that the non-conformance has not recurred
- Document the verification in the CAPA record

If effectiveness is not demonstrated, reopen the CAPA and revise the action plan.

Step 8: Closure

The CAPA is closed when:

- All actions are completed
- Effectiveness is verified
- Documentation is complete
- QA Manager approves closure

CAPA Prioritization

Priority 1: Safety or regulatory issue. Complete within 14 days. Priority 2: Customer impact or significant quality issue. Complete within 30 days. Priority 3: Process improvement. Complete within 60 days.

Related Documents

- SOP-QA-012: Non-Conformance Report Procedure
- SOP-QA-008: Internal Audit Procedure

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